ESSAY WRITING RUINED

Or 3 pirate **lessons** on how to eyeball a passing essay under stress when you're not a native English speaker.



Jerónimo Visñovezky

INCLUDES AN **AUTOMATIC SELF WRITING** CONCLUSION

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by Jerónimo Visñovezky

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THE RECIPE AND THE SECRET SAUCE

The secret

This is a series of three lessons tailored to people that struggle to get a passing mark in essay writing tasks. Specially in stressful situations such as an English Language test.

We developed them as we struggled ourselves to produce essays that read smoothly while not being proficient in English yet.

The tips are simple. If you struggle to find ideas about a topic and you don't know a lot of vocabulary to write about those ideas then, in a nutshell, you can do this:

- Open the essay with a general statement, a rhetorical question or a quote.
- Do not name your ideas in the thesis statement. Just say how many they are: *"Uniforms are good for two main reasons."*
- Name your ideas in the topic sentences of each body paragraph. P1: *"Uniforms foster equality."* P2: *"Uniforms encourage good behaviour."*
- To avoid sounding repetitive, change the order of the ideas in the summary of the conclusion. *"In conclusion, because they*

encourage good behaviour while also fostering equality, we believe uniforms are ultimately good."

If you understand what you need to do now, stop reading. This is all the advice we have.

Who do we think you are?

Our ideal student needs to write an essay fast but does not know where to start.

We write these lessons, first, as we said a moment ago for a younger version of ourselves. For people that have recently started training to become teachers, who are learning a foreign language and -at the same time- have to produce complex, academic pieces of writing. If you are failing, if you struggle with time, ideas and vocabulary then pay attention. These lessons may help.

We also write for some of our students. That is why our discussion of paragraphs is so simplistic and we explain some terms like *"topic sentence."* Maybe others can also benefit from our guidance.

If you are already an English Teacher or an advanced student who is proficient, fluent and a master paraphraser these lessons are not for you.

These lessons have tricks, tips and shortcuts that are like training wheels. As soon as you start writing with more vocabulary, about topics you are familiar with,

you will stop using them. Until you find yourself in the same situation: you have to write an essay, you have to do it fast and you do not know where to start.

English, the straight arrow and why some fail

Different cultures have different ways of organising ideas. Spanish speakers, for example, tend to digress. They may go on a tangent before coming back to the main idea. English teachers are trained to make sure students write paragraphs and essays following the Anglo-Saxon tradition which has a simpler, linear logic (often depicted by a straight arrow pointing down) So, one reason your writing may be failing to get a passing grade is that you are writing your essays with a structure that your teacher identifies as incorrect.

Here we will focus on making sure you use the right structure. As an added bonus, along the way, we will also share some tips on how to manage information. So even if you know very little about the topic you need to deal with, you can produce a piece of writing that is clear and easy to read.

That alone will not warrant a passing grade if you have language problems and fail to produce lexically and grammatically accurate English sentences. But even then, we promise you, a sound structure will help make those mistakes easier to digest.

You should treat the advice that follows as a series of suggestions that never contradict what your teacher requires from you. Should you feel a tip does just that -contradicts your teacher- avoid it altogether or modify it to fit your teacher's criteria.

The structures we propose are not a sequence the essay *must* have, but one that it *can* have.

Also, we will not deal in depth with different essay types but instead we will focus on its general characteristics. All introductions, we will argue here, have the same function: catch the attention of the reader and state what the essay is going to be about. All conclusions circle back to the introduction and summarise the essay. We will speak about how to make sure those general aspects are so well executed that the teacher has no choice but to grant a passing grade.

Why would a teacher oppose these lessons and why you should take them anyway.

Structure based writing has never won any Pulitzer Prizes. Essay writing in particular, but really writing in general, is actually about reading. Do you want to write an essay that the New York Times will agree to publish? Read about a topic for years. Then, when you sit down and write about it, you will notice your points are clear, your ideas are well connected and your vocabulary is impeccable.

Shifting the focus to structure seems to be neither good advice nor the path to writing thought provoking, life changing essays. And we agree, but we also know how limited can a student's sources be. Students of English as a foreign language seldom read more than one or two texts about a topic before being required to produce 250 to 400 words in 40 to 60 minutes.

Now you have a problem: the clock is ticking and you remember only a couple of facts, just two ideas with which you can write a good sentence but not a half decent paragraph. Forget about a 300-word essay.

Well, think again. These short lessons will teach you how to do just that: Write hundreds of words on a topic you remember only two facts about. Even if you have a very limited vocabulary to express those two facts.

We have used these techniques -these *"tips"*- and they have worked countless times. We have yet to see them fail. After all these years, The New York Times has never requested our services. Also, we have never failed a writing task. Here is our secret sauce.

LESSON 1, THE INTRODUCTION AND THE THESIS STATEMENT

The first sentence

The *"Thesis statement"* is a fancy name for *"What this essay is about"* and it is usually the last sentence of the introduction. Here, however, we will start from the beginning: What is the first sentence we write? Imagine the rubric asks to write 250 words about the question *"Are school uniforms still a good idea?"* If you look at its function, the first sentence is supposed to catch the reader's attention. Here are a few proven ways to do just that.

1 - A general statement: "School uniforms are under scrutiny and this time they may not survive."

2 - Addressing the reader: "If you have attended a school, you have probably used a uniform."

3 - A quotation: "Philip Slater once said 'A person in a uniform is merely an extension of another person's will.'"

4 - A rhetorical question: "Have you ever stopped to think about why we use uniforms at school?"

5 - Data in numbers: "A recent poll in Springfield showed 87% of students are actually happy to wear a uniform."

Remember: the introduction is a paragraph

You have a first sentence, should you jump into the thesis statement? In most cases, to our taste, a mere two sentence paragraph is too short. Here, between the first sentence and the thesis statement we would recommend to use some filler text. A good strategy is to look at the rubric for inspiration -or even to paraphrase it.

If the rubric asks to write 250 words about the question *"Are school uniforms still a good idea?"* your second and third sentences could be:

"Some even wonder whether they are a good idea or not. We believe they certainly are."

It is vital ***not*** to use key vocabulary in this filler text. We should save that for the body. But it is important to add a couple of sentences. Otherwise, your teacher may notice the introduction is *"too thin"* and pay attention to see what is wrong with it. And we do not want that. Here is a picture.



The thesis statement must NOT be perfect

This is perhaps the most important part of your essay. Its function is to state what the essay is going to be about. Therefore, if you do not have a clear idea of what you are going to say it will show in the thesis statement. So, take a minute or two to make a mental plan of what you want to say. Perhaps you can even jot down an outline.

Another problem is that you may not be an expert in this topic. Imagine you read the question and come up with three reasons why school uniforms are actually a good idea.

- they simplify students' lives
- they make students act responsibly outside school
- they make students feel equal

Thus, a perfect thesis statement would say:

"School uniforms are a good choice because they simplify students' lives, they make them act responsibly outside school, and they make students feel equal."

Now this thesis is perfect but if you burn all of your precious ideas now, what will you say in the body paragraphs? Here, you may wonder: Is there a way to write a thesis statement that tells you what the essay is going to be about *without* telling you what the essay is going to be about? And the answer is *yes*, there is.

Here's another complication we have not mentioned before: as a student your ability to paraphrase may be limited. Especially when the topic is new to you. So here are all of the places where you will need to discuss or name your precious three reasons.

- **First**, you name them in the thesis statement in the introduction.
- **Second**, you name them again in the first sentence (called topic sentence) of the paragraph that deals with that particular reason.
- **Third**, the second sentence of each paragraph is typically a supporting idea where you will need to talk about the same reason again.
- **Fourth**, the conclusion has a summary of the essay and you need to name your reasons once more there.

If you just repeat *"They simplify students' lives"* four times you will not get a prize for vocabulary range. So, what do you do? Well, in the introduction we can simply write the thesis statement like this:

"School uniforms are a good choice because of three main reasons."

Here you have just provided an idea of your perspective, what is the essay about and also a hint into its future shape. We expect this essay to talk

about three *"reasons"*. We used *"reasons"* here because it was a good fit but you can talk about **characteristics, aspects, factors, steps, processes** and so on. Never use overgeneralising words like *"things"* or *"stuff"*, though. They may cost you a failing mark.

Finally, we used *"main"* because we do not know if the three reasons you thought about are the *only* three reasons in the whole wide world. Words such as **main, major, key, central, predominant** and so on, cover you from misrepresenting an issue.

Look at what we have written so far:

Write 250 words about the question:

Are school uniforms still a good idea?

School uniforms are under scrutiny and this time they may not survive. Some even wonder whether they are a good idea or not. We believe that school uniforms are a good choice because of three main reasons.

Notice that, for the final text, we merged sentence 3 with the thesis. Imagine you want to, or need to, include a paragraph with counter arguments. We could then say:

School uniforms are under scrutiny and this time they may not survive. Some even wonder whether they are a good idea or not. Even though there is valid

criticism, we believe that school uniforms are an excellent choice because of three main reasons.

The secret recipe for our introduction is

a) A sentence that catches the reader's attention.
b) Filler text inspired by the rubric.
c) A thesis statement that only mentions how many ideas you had for this essay.

Remember this in not a sequence the introduction *must* have but one it *can* have if you are unable to come up with something better.

Activity 1

a- Find an essay question you like (or hate).
b- Write a catchy first sentences using one of the strategies you have learnt.
c- Write one or two filler sentences playing with (or paraphrasing) the question.
d- Write a thesis statement that tells you what the essay is about without naming any controlling ideas.
e- Read your introduction and, if necessary, edit it so it makes sense and it is easy to read.

LESSON 2, THE BODY AND ITS PARAGRAPHS

What a paragraph is and what it is not

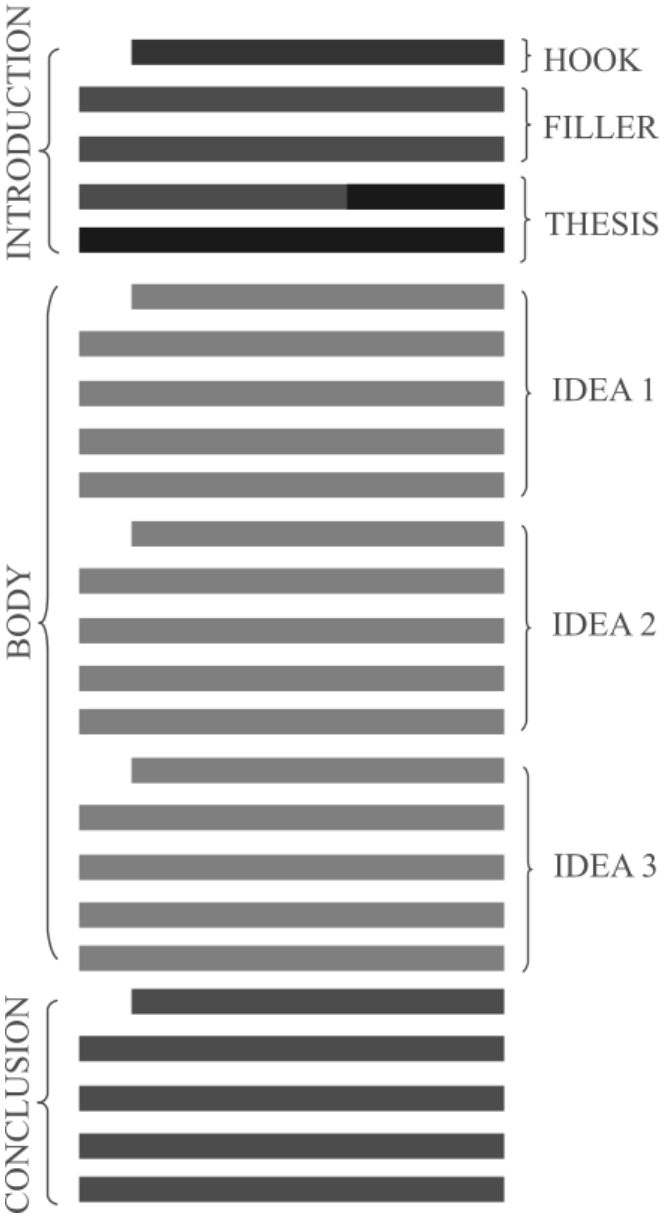
The first mistake you can make when writing the body is not knowing what a paragraph is. Should you end the next sentence with a full stop and start a new line or not?

Let us look at not one, nor two, but three definitions of the word paragraph. We kept the American spelling for some of these.

> **Wikipedia**: A paragraph is a self-contained unit of a discourse in writing dealing with a particular point or idea.
>
> **Indiana University**: A paragraph is a series of sentences that are organized and coherent, and are all related to a single topic.
>
> **time4writing.com**: A paragraph is a group of sentences organized around a central topic.

It looks to us as if, no matter where you look, there was consensus: one idea per paragraph.

If you have read essays before, you can probably count the number of paragraphs from a distance. So, you should start a new line -a new paragraph- only when you are going to talk about a new idea.


INTRODUCTION
HOOK
FILLER
THESIS
BODY
IDEA 1
IDEA 2
IDEA 3
CONCLUSION

A one sentence paragraph is technically still a paragraph. *But* if you just started a new line for no reason and keep creating loose sentences about the same topic, then they are not paragraphs. Write one paragraph per controlling idea. See *"The parts of a simple and a complex paragraph"* below for examples of controlling ideas and supporting ideas.

Paragraphs and information management

We made a promise at the beginning: That these lessons will teach you how to write hundreds of words on a topic you remember only two facts about. So far, given an essay question about uniforms, you have come up with only three ideas and up to this moment you have not even mentioned them. Well, now is the time.

The first sentence of each paragraph -referred to as the *topic sentence*- tells you what the paragraph talks about[1]. It mentions what is its topic -school uniforms- and its controlling idea -simplify student's lives. Here you burn your best vocabulary items because your teacher will be paying attention.

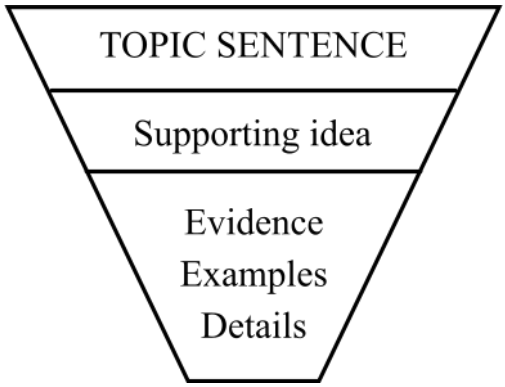
"First, school uniforms simplify students' lives."

That's it. The topic sentence is perfect. Now what?

[1] Oshima and Hogue,1998, give examples of topic sentences placed at the beginning, at the end of a paragraph or "sandwitch-style" being the first *and* last sentences. These configurations are true but far less common so we do not deal with them here.

The parts of a simple and a complex paragraph

Like the essays published by the New York Times, paragraphs can get quite intricate. Typically, the information will go from general to specific.



If you have a firm grasp of the topic and feel confident enough to just write about it: Do that. Write what you know, say what you want to say. Here, however, we will try to provide a simple structural sequence you can follow when you *do not* know what to say next. Again, these are sequences that a paragraph *can* have. If you can remember what comes next in the structure, you may be able to continue writing even if you feel the writers' block setting in.

1st, the topic sentence.
School uniforms simplify students' lives.
2nd, a supporting idea.
Students do not need to think about what to wear.

3rd, evidence, examples, details.
In fact, worrying about clothes is an important source of stress among teenagers.
4th, and optional, a concluding sentence that refers back to the topic sentence.
So, uniforms definitely help make matters simpler.

Sometimes, you will have a more complex topic that has, say, two supporting ideas. Here is a possible layout.

1st, the topic sentence.
School uniforms simplify students' lives.
2nd, a supporting idea.
Students do not need to think about what to wear.
3rd, evidence, examples, details.
In fact, worrying about clothes is an important source of stress among teenagers.
4th, another supporting idea.
Students are then allowed to focus on academic achievement.
5th, evidence, examples, details for the second idea.
Such as attending class, doing homework and preparing for tests.
6th, a concluding sentence.
So, uniforms definitely help make matters simpler.

In general, we see concluding sentences as optional when the paragraphs are part of an essay because there will be a concluding paragraph at the end[2]. It is a way of saving your concluding ideas for that final paragraph while also avoiding *yet another* mention of the same vocabulary or its synonyms (wink, wink)

Grammatical range in paragraphs

Perhaps there is a defect in the sequence of sentences we are planning to include in paragraph one. They may be grammatically accurate but there is no range. We should be able to write in a variety of sentence types. Here is a list you can use:

1- Simple affirmative sentences.

Usually subject, verb, complement.

School uniforms simplify students' lives.

2- Simple negative sentences.

Remember affirmative statement are not the only way to express an idea.

Students do not need to think about what to wear.

3- Simple questions.

[2] *"A concluding sentence is not absolutely necessary; in fact, a concluding sentence is not customary for every paragraph in a multiparagraph essay."* Oshima and Hogue, 1998.

Questions may not fit everywhere but an opening rhetorical question in the introduction is a good place to put one.

Have you ever stopped to think about why we use uniforms at school?

4- Compound sentences. Coordinated sentences.

Coordination joins two (or more) full sentences with a coordinating conjunction such as "and", "or", "but" and “so”.

Students do not need to think about what to wear and they are allowed to focus on academic achievement.

5- Complex sentences. Subordinated clauses.

A main clause (one that has meaning on itself) is joined to a subordinate clause (one that needs the main clause to complete its meaning) with a subordinating conjunction. Write more of this type.

Students feel less stressed when they wear a uniform.

Students can focus on important aspects because they wear a uniform.

Uniforms are still under scrutiny even though they have proved to have positive impact on students.

6- Passive voice sentences.

You take the object of an active sentence and make it the subject of a passive sentence where it receives the action of the verb.

Uniforms <u>are being</u> questioned.

Students <u>are</u> then <u>allowed</u> to focus on academic achievement.

Good paragraph characteristics to keep in mind

- **Cohesion**: Use synonyms, pronouns and connectors[3] to glue the paragraph together in a cohesive unit.[4]
- **Coherence**: If people can understand it, it is coherent. If it does not make sense, you need to rewrite.
- **Register**: If it is a formal piece of writing, do away with informal lexicon and contractions.
- **Balance and proportions**: If one paragraph are 50 words, all other paragraphs should be around 50. Maybe bigger if it makes an important point but you should not have a 200-word paragraph.

What we have written plus paragraphs 2 and 3

Write 250 words about the question:

[3] Be careful. Using connectors in every sentence may be just as confusing as omitting them.

[4] Some authors use *coherence* to mean both *cohesion* and *coherence*.

Are school uniforms still a good idea?

School uniforms are under scrutiny and this time they may not survive. Some even wonder whether they are a good idea or not. We believe that school uniforms are an excellent choice because of three main reasons.

First, school uniforms simplify students' lives. An important consequence is that they do not need to think about what to wear. In fact, worrying about clothes is an important source of stress among teenagers. Another consequence is that students are then allowed to focus on academic achievement such as attending class, doing homework and preparing for tests.

Second, school uniforms make students act responsibly outside school. On the one hand, people may recognise the uniform and report any misbehaviour to the school. Parents of the same institution are usually the witnesses. On the other hand, it is students themselves who understand they owe respect to their educational institution. Perhaps that is why a recent survey suggests teenagers are far less likely to misbehave while in uniform.

Finally, school uniforms make students feel equal. They tend to follow styles and sizes that do not accentuate the shape of the body and therefore help avoid body shaming. But the main equality school uniforms foster is a social one. Expensive clothes are

a sign of economic status which may, in turn, foster asymmetric social relationships among peers. Uniforms put every student on a level plane field.

Notice the way we connected the paragraphs may not be the most appropriate. *"First, second and third"* may be better suited for a process than to three independent reasons. Still, we will leave it like that to keep it real. What connector would you have used?

Activity 2

a- Find the introduction you wrote for activity 1 and write the body.

b- Try to include as many sentence types as possible.

c- Make sure cohesion, coherence, register and balance are under control.

LESSON 3, THE CONCLUSION

The conclusion and information management

If writing under stress is difficult, writing the conclusion is almost impossible. The clock is ticking and all the time you had has almost run out. The teacher is pacing impatiently and announcing you will have to hand in your text soon. Unsurprisingly, it is under these conditions we developed a quick way to write a fool proof conclusion with *zero* new vocabulary.

Our promise had been to maximise the very few ideas you had about the topic and help you write hundreds of words. So, we told you how to omit their mention in the thesis statement. We advised you to use the ideas in the topic sentences of each body paragraph. Now we are going to explain how to rearrange the information using the same -or very similar- vocabulary for a flawless conclusion. In order to do that we are going to look at those first three ideas once again. Watch the conclusion write itself.

The self-writing conclusion

A rookie mistake here is to introduce new reasons, facts, aspects, or characteristics. By design conclusions recapitulate and (maybe) provide an opinion. They *do not* add material that has not been mentioned in the body. Writing the conclusion now is

a matter of re arranging the information so it does not sound repetitive in the summary.

Here is what we had said so far:

Thesis: Uniforms are good for three main reasons.

Paragraph 1: they simplify students' lives

Paragraph 2: they make students act responsibly outside school

Paragraph 3: they make students feel equal

So, all you do now is writing a sentence or sentences changing the order of the information so as to avoid sounding like a broken record.

If your essay says: *Uniforms are good for reasons 1, 2, and 3.*

You can flip the structure and write *Because of reasons 1, 2 and 3; uniforms are good*.

Or flip the structure and rearrange the information as in *Because of reasons 2, 3 and 1; uniforms are good.*

You start with a connector such as -surprise, surprise- *"In conclusion"* or *"To sum up."*

Conclusion 1:

In conclusion, because they help students live simpler lives, act responsibly and feel equal, school uniforms are still a very good choice. In my opinion, they should be mandatory in all primary and secondary

schools and we should advocate their adoption as much as possible.

Conclusion 2

In conclusion, because they help students act responsibly, feel equal and live simpler lives, school uniforms are still a very good choice. In my opinion, they should be mandatory in all primary and secondary schools and we should advocate their adoption as much as possible.

You can always play with variations. You can, for example, change the grammatical category of a word or group of words.

Conclusion 3

To sum up, school uniforms are an excellent choice because of the way they instil simplicity, responsibility and equality in students. It is precisely for this reason that, in my opinion, school uniforms should be compulsory in all schools and we should even be advocating for wider adoption as much as humanly possible.

What we have written

Write 250 words about the question:

Are school uniforms still a good idea?

School uniforms are under scrutiny and this time they may not survive. Some even wonder whether they are

a good idea or not. We believe that school uniforms are an excellent choice because of three main reasons.

First, school uniforms simplify students' lives. An important consequence is that they do not need to think about what to wear. In fact, worrying about clothes is an important source of stress among teenagers. Another consequence is that students are then allowed to focus on academic achievement such as attending class, doing homework and preparing for tests.

Second, school uniforms make students act responsibly outside school. On the one hand, people may recognise the uniform and report any misbehaviour to the school. Parents of the same institution are usually the witnesses. On the other hand, it is students themselves who understand they owe respect to their educational institution. Perhaps that is why a recent survey suggests teenagers are far less likely to misbehave while in uniform.

Finally, school uniforms make students feel equal. They tend to follow styles and sizes that do not accentuate the shape of the body and therefore help avoid body shaming. But the main equality school uniforms foster is a social one. Expensive clothes are a sign of economic status which may, in turn, foster asymmetric social relationships among peers. Uniforms put every student on a level plane field.

In conclusion, because they help students act responsibly, feel equal and live simpler lives, school uniforms are still a very good choice. In my opinion, they should be mandatory in all primary and secondary schools and we should advocate their adoption as much as possible.

Final wordcount: 275

It is always a good idea to practice essay writing aiming at a higher wordcount. 270 is fine for a 250-word requirement so you make sure you are never short. Try not to go over 300.

Our educated guess is that when you are supposed to be learning how to write essays, producing one that so clearly conforms to its structure, may persuade your teacher that you are on the right track.

Here is another version that follows our advice.

School Uniforms

Have you ever stopped to think about why we use school uniforms? When we do, it turns out, some tend to question why we do it. Some, on the other hand, point out the reasons why they are good for students. Despite the criticism school uniforms receive, I think they are the most adequate choice for two main reasons.

Critics of school uniforms maintain they restrict students' freedom of expression. That means uniforms

promote conformity over individuality. For instance, if you had a favourite colour you like to wear, you would not be able to do so. In fact, the colours of the school you attend are the only colours allowed.

But even then, school uniforms create a level playing field among students, reducing peer pressure and bullying. Imagine if some students wore Gucci and others wore "hand me down" clothes. That means you could spend a lot of time in front of the mirror and still never look nice enough.

Consequently, school uniforms keep students focused on their education, not their clothes. They remove the burden and the stress of having to choose what to wear every single day. With the apparel out of the equation you can direct your attention to more important matters.

In conclusion, in spite of accusations of school uniforms restricting freedom I think they are the best choice because the reduce peer pressure and allow you to focus on education rather than clothing. In my opinion, opponents of school uniforms just fail to see the big picture.

Wordcount 253, phew!

When you have to pass an English language exam that includes essay writing with a given number of words and a time constraint you should first focus on accuracy. Take your time. Write slowly. Make sure

the essay has no mistakes. *Then*, when accuracy has been achieved focus on speed. You will find that it only takes a few essays to become fast.

Now finish your essay.

Activity 3

a- Write the conclusion for your essay.
b- Make sure the controlling ideas do not sound repetitive in the summary.
c- Include your opinion.

APPENDIX 1: PATTERNS OF ESSAY ORGANISATION

Credit where its due

This classification comes chiefly from Oshima and Hogue (2009) Writing Academic English (The Longman Academic Writing Series, Level 4)

Logical Division of Ideas

Main Parts of an Essay

1. An essay has three main parts: an introduction, a body, and a conclusion.

• The introductory paragraph consists of two parts: a few general statements to attract your reader's attention and a thesis statement to state your main idea. A thesis statement may also name the major subdivisions of the topic, and it may indicate how you will organize the essay.

• The body of an essay discusses the subtopics, one by one. It contains as many paragraphs as necessary to explain all subtopics.

• The concluding paragraph reminds your reader of what you have said.

In it, you summarize your main ideas or paraphrase your thesis. You may also make a final comment on the topic for your reader to remember.

2. Use the logical division of ideas pattern to divide a topic into separate paragraphs.

3. Link paragraphs with transitions; that is, show how one paragraph is related to the next by using appropriate transition words, phrases, or clauses.

4. Prepare an outline to organize your ideas before you begin to write.

Logical Division of Ideas

Transition Words and Phrases

- first, first of all, second, third, etc.
- next, last, finally
- also, in addition, moreover, furthermore

Coordinators

- and
- both . . . and
- not only... but also

Others

- the first cause, reason, factor, etc.
- the/a second problem, result,
- advantage, etc.
- one problem, reason, important
- factor, etc.
- another way, reason, disadvantage, etc.
- an additional problem, result, etc.
- in addition to math and science,

Argumentative Essays

1. An argumentative essay is a land of essay in which you try to persuade your reader to agree with your opinion about a controversial topic.

2. An argumentative essay contains these five elements:

• An explanation of the issue

• A clear thesis statement

• A summary of the opposing arguments

• Rebuttals to the opposing arguments

• Your own arguments

3. Use either a block pattern or a point-by-point pattern. Be sure to include the opposite point of view as well as your own.

4. Use contrast transition signals to connect opposing arguments and your counter-arguments

Vocabulary for argumentative writing

- Supporters, Opponents
- Proponents, Opponents
- Those in favour of …, Those opposed to …
- Defenders of …, Critics of …
- Advocates of …, Objectors
- Pro-… (e.g. Pro-abortionists), Anti-… (e.g. Anti-abortionists)

say that …

- argue
- claim
- maintain
- contend
- allege
- insist
- contend
- suggest
- point out

Comparison/Contrast Essay

Comparison/contrast is a common pattern for writing about similarities and differences. It is used in all academic fields.

2. There are two common ways to organize a comparison/contrast essay.

• In point-by-point organization, you discuss each similarity and each difference in some other order— usually order of their importance— without grouping them into blocks. In this type of organization, you may discuss a similarity and then a difference, and then a similarity and then a difference.

• In block organization, you first discuss all the similarities in a block and then all the differences in another block. (You may, of course, begin with the block of differences.)

3. Use comparison and contrast signal words to help your reader understand your points of comparison and contrast.

Comparison Signal Words

Transition Words and Phrases

- similarly
- likewise
- also
- too

Subordinators

- as
- just as

Coordinators

- and
- both . . . and
- not only... but also
- neither... nor

Others

- like (+ noun)
- just like (+ noun)
- similar to (+ noun
- (be) like
- (be) similar (to)
- (be) the same as
- (be) the same
- (be) alike

- (be) similar
- to compare (to/with)

Contrast Signal Words: Concession (Unexpected Result)

Transition Words and Phrases

- however
- nevertheless
- nonetheless
- still

Subordinators

- although
- even though
- though

Coordinators

- but
- yet

Others

- despite (+ noun)
- in spite of (+ noun)

Contrast Signal Words: Direct Opposition

Transition Words and Phrases

- however
- in contrast
- in (by) comparison
- on the other hand
- on the contrary

Subordinators

- while
- whereas

Coordinators

- but

Others

- differ (from)
- compared (to/with)
- (be) different (from)
- (be) dissimilar to
- (be) unlike

Cause/Effect Essays

1. Cause/effect organization is a common pattern in academic writing to write about causes (or reasons) and effects (or results).

2. There are two common cause/effect patterns of organization.

• In block organization, the causes (or reasons) are grouped together in one block, and the effects (or results) are grouped together in another block. There may be a transition paragraph between blocks.

• In chain organization, the causes and effects are too closely linked to be separated. One cause leads to an effect, which is the cause of the next effect.

3. Use a variety of cause/effect signal words to help your reader follow your ideas.

Cause Signal Words

Coordinators

- for

Subordinators

- because
- since
- as

Others

- to result from
- to be the result of
- due to
- because of
- the effect of
- the consequence of
- as a result of
- as a consequence of

Effect Signal Words

Transition Words and Phrases

- as a result
- as a consequence
- therefore
- thus
- consequently
- hence

Coordinators

- so

Others

- to result in
- to cause
- to have an effect on
- to affect
- the cause of
- the reason for
- thereby

Chronological Order: Process Essays

1. Using chronological order to organize an essay means putting the ideas in order or sequence by occurrence in time.

2. Use chronological order for narrative essays (stories, history, biography, and autobiography) and for process essays (how to do or make something).

3. Following are the three keys to success in writing a chronological order essay:

• Group the steps or events into paragraphs where natural breaks occur.

• Write a thesis statement that indicates chronological order.

• Use chronological order signal words and phrases to show the sequence of steps (in a process) or events (in a narration).

Chronological Order Signal Words and Phrases

- first, first of all, second, third, etc.
- then, next, after that, soon, later, later on
- finally, last, last of all
- meanwhile, at the same time, now
- gradually, eventually

Subordinators

- after, since, as, until, as soon as, when, before, while

Others

- the first (second, last, final) step
- on the third day
- after leaving home
- later that morning
- for five minutes
- in 2004
- several years ago
- a few weeks later
- in the next (past, last) 15 years

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